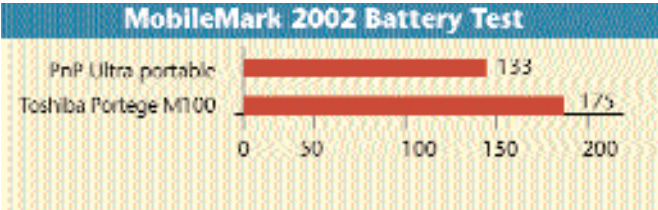


test drive ■ laptops



Decision Maker				
	Laptop for your desk	An office laptop	Laptop for travellers	Laptops for flaunting
You need:	A reasonably well-powered laptop that can replace your desktop PC, and provide the same amount of processing power with some battery backup	A sturdy, light, decently configured laptop that can run most of your office, and also has wireless connectivity. Centrino based laptops would be great choice	An extremely light, portable laptop that can be used anywhere, is easy on shoulders and allows you to do most of your office work plus browsing Via hotspots	A laptop that looks like a dream, has a high flaunt value and differentiates you from the crowd
Look for:	Processor above 2 GHz, with atleast 512 MB of RAM, a decent ATi or nVidia based graphics adapter, 60 GB above hard disk space and array of connectivity options	A laptop with 1.4 GHz Pentium M processor, at least 256 MB of RAM, 40 GB hard disk and a battery life of more than three hours	Anything that weighs 1.5 Kgs or less, is built around the Centrino platform and at least three hours of battery life	Tablets or convertibles laptops, with certain exceptions in mainstream laptops
Our pick:	Aci Ultima, Aci Emerald Pro, Dell Inspiron 1100 and Fujitsu LBC 2220	IBM T40, HP-Compaq Nx9000, Wipro Little genius and Zenith 4x	Toshiba M100, IBM T40 and PnP laptop.	Toshiba Portege 3500, Acer C110 and Hp-Compaq nx-9000
Price:	Rs 74,000 to Rs 1,25,000	Rs 70,000 to Rs 1,75,000	Above Rs 1,00,000	Above Rs 1,50,000

Contact details				
Brand	Aci	Acer	Apple	BPL
Contact	ACI Asia Ltd	Acer India Pvt Ltd	Apple Computer International Pvt. Ltd.	XServe India Pvt Ltd
phone	022-56943260 / 56407000	080 5219531-34	080-5550575	080-5572601/02
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Website	www.aci-asia.com	www.acer.com	www.apple.com	None
Brand	Fujitsu	IBM	Hp-Compaq	Wipro
Contact	Aci infocom Ltd	IBM India Ltd	Infobahn Technical Solutions India Ltd	Wipro Ltd
phone	022 - 2826 6031/32	080 2063199	022-28500821	080-8440011
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Website	www.fujitsu.com	www.ibm.com	www.hp.com	www.wepindia.com
Brand	Toshiba	Zenith	PnP	Dell
Contact	HCL Infosystems Ltd	Zenith Computers Ltd	Plug N Play Technologies	Dell Computers Asia Pvt Ltd
phone	0120-4544534	022-28377300	022- 5634 8784	1-600-33-8044
Fax	0120-4533877	022-28377297	022-5634 0276	080-5586107
Email	notebook@hclinsys.com	one-up@zenith-india.com	sales@plugnplaytech.com	marketing_response@dell.com
Website	www.toshiba.com	www.zenith-india.com	none	www.dell.com

Conclusion

Ultra-portables are made with one purpose in mind—portability for frequent travellers. Miniaturisation leads to increase in the price, and hence these devices are very expensive, making them quite a rare commodity. But the scene is changing rapidly, and nearly all vendors such as IBM, HP-Compaq, Dell, Toshiba, etc., have come out with a range of ultra-portables based on the new Centrino platform. This platform offers smaller chips with higher processing power and lower power consumption. It also offers wireless connectivity, thus greatly improving any mobile device that runs on Centrino. The Toshiba M100 featured in this shoot-out was the only ultra-portable from a reputed brand; the PnP brand laptop, on the other hand, comes from an Indian vendor who assembles them in India, and currently has a presence only in Mumbai.

The Toshiba M100, despite being an ultra-portable, had some distinct features such as the inclusion of the optical drive with-

out significant increase in the bulk, the champagne finish and exclusion of touchpad. On the pure performance stake, it betters even the thin and light category winner IBM T40 and there is no doubting its abilities when it comes to the task. The omission of the touch pad was felt badly initially, but the well placed track point compensated for the loss. The price of the M100 is a bit steep, but that's what they cost. Whereas on the other hand, the PnP laptop just can't match the Toshiba in either performance or features. This was the only laptop weighing below 1.5 Kgs, and allows great mobility. The PnP does its job, provided you use it as it was meant to be—any diversion here and there, and it will go bonkers. You can probably get a laptop with a much better configuration for the same price, but nothing that will offer you the same portability.

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